



Security Council

Seventy-seventh year

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Provisional

President: Mrs. Thomas-Greenfield (United States of America)

Members:

Albania	Mr. Spasse
Brazil	Mr. De Almeida Filho
China	Mr. Dai Bing
France	Mr. De Rivière
Gabon	Mrs. Ngyema Ndong
Ghana	Mrs. Hackman
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Mexico	Mr. Gómez Robledo Verduzco
Norway	Ms. Juul
Russian Federation	Ms. Evstigneeva
United Arab Emirates	Mrs. Alhefeiti
United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland . .	Mr. Kariuki

Agenda

The situation concerning the Democratic Republic of the Congo

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The meeting was called to order at 3.05 p.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

The situation concerning the Democratic Republic of the Congo

The President: In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representatives of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Rwanda and Uganda to participate in this meeting.

On behalf of the Council, I welcome His Excellency Mr. Christophe Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

In accordance with rule 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the following briefers to participate in this meeting: Ms. Martha Ama Akyaa Pobee, Assistant Secretary-General for Africa in the Departments of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs and Peace Operations, and Mr. Huang Xia, Special Envoy of the Secretary-General for the Great Lakes Region.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I give the floor to Ms. Pobee.

Ms. Pobee (*spoke in French*): I am grateful for the opportunity to update the Security Council on recent developments in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo and the actions taken by the United Nations in that regard. Despite the efforts of the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo to combat insecurity in the eastern part of the country, violence committed by armed groups continues to inflict a heavy toll on the civilian population in several areas in the provinces. What was already a dire situation is growing worse, specifically owing to the recent resurgence of the Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23) and its hostile activity in North Kivu against the Congolese armed forces and the peacekeepers of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), which constitutes a serious threat to peace, security and stability in the region.

(*spoke in English*)

The Council has already received two factual updates since 22 May on the operational developments in Rutshuru, so I will not touch on those developments. As of 30 May, the Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo (FARDC) had secured route nationale 2, which remains open to traffic. As of now, the situation is reportedly calm in the territories of Nyiragongo and Rutshuru, including in the Tehanzu and Runyoni hills, as the FARDC and the M-23 continue to hold their positions. Two MONUSCO peacekeepers sustained minor injuries over the course of the hostilities, and there was limited damage to the Mission's materiel. The FARDC reports having suffered at least 16 fatalities and 22 injured to date. I want to take this opportunity to extend my heartfelt condolences to the families of the victims and to the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as to wish a speedy recovery to the injured.

The humanitarian impact of the M-23 attacks has been significant. The Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs reports that as of 30 May, at least 75,000 persons had been internally displaced and another 11,557 had crossed the border into Uganda. While there is no immediate threat assessed to the population and United Nations personnel in Goma, the situation remains fluid and is highly volatile. MONUSCO and humanitarian actors are monitoring the situation and ensuring the mapping of displacement areas. United Nations agencies and partners immediately started distributing assistance to 35,000 people in the areas affected. On 28 May, the Deputy Humanitarian Coordinator, together with other humanitarian actors, visited internally displaced persons sites in Nyiragongo territory with a view to assessing the situation and ensuring the mobilization of additional support for the growing humanitarian needs there.

Urgent action is required to de-escalate the current situation. The M-23's resumption of hostilities has been roundly condemned by Special Representative of the Secretary-General Keita, Special Envoy Xia, the Council and key regional and international partners. They have called unanimously for the M-23 to immediately lay down its arms and enter the disarmament process within the framework of the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme. It is imperative that the Council lend its full weight to the ongoing regional efforts to defuse the situation and bring an end to the

M-23 insurgency once and for all. I am encouraged by the fact that Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo have decided to refer to the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism (EJVM) of the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region to investigate reported instances of human and material damage caused by explosive ordnance originating from behind their respective borders on 23 May.

I am also encouraged by the calls that President Macky Sall of Senegal, Chairperson of the African Union, has made to Presidents Tshisekedi and Kagame to urge for calm and the peaceful resolution of any disagreements. Indeed, every effort should be made to ensure that the parties make full use of existing mechanisms such as the EJVM, which play an essential role in maintaining the climate of trust and cooperation that continues to be crucial to effectively tackling the security challenges facing both the Democratic Republic of the Congo and its neighbours. Continued dialogue between the Governments concerned remains indispensable to preventing a further escalation of violence in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. Special Representative Keita and Special Envoy Xia have been actively engaged in efforts to de-escalate tensions through their good offices, and Mr. Xia will be elaborating on his ongoing and planned activities in that regard.

We cannot lose sight of the fact that armed violence remains widespread throughout the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. Whether in Ituri, South Kivu or other parts of North Kivu, a multitude of armed groups continue to prey on the civilian population, undermining efforts to achieve lasting peace, stability and development in those regions and indeed the whole country. The two-track process launched in Nairobi on 21 April at the second Regional Heads of State Conclave on the Democratic Republic of the Congo has given fresh impetus to the Government's efforts to bring local Congolese armed groups into the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme and find durable solutions to the continued presence of foreign armed groups on Congolese soil. I want to echo the Secretary-General in commending the leadership of Presidents Kenyatta and Tshisekedi in that process and encouraging them to spare no effort to achieve a successful outcome. I reiterate the Secretary-General's call to local armed groups in the Democratic Republic of the Congo to participate in the political process without preconditions, and to all foreign armed

groups to disarm unconditionally and immediately return to their countries of origin, in accordance with the decisions of the Nairobi Conclave.

I also want to underscore the importance of involving women, including civil-society representatives and those affiliated with armed groups, in the ongoing efforts so as to ensure that their specific needs and perspectives are considered in the search for inclusive and durable solutions. MONUSCO and the Office of the Special Envoy of the Secretary-General for the Great Lakes Region are working hand in hand to support the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Kenyan facilitation in their consultations with Congolese armed groups, through the provision of logistical support and expert advice. The continued support of the Council and international partners for this ambitious undertaking, aimed at removing the security-related obstacles that have prevented the Democratic Republic of the Congo from realizing its full economic potential, will remain critical as the process unfolds over the coming weeks and months.

The full launching of the operational cell of the Contact and Coordination Group, as a complement to the Nairobi process and the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme, remains an essential component in the efforts to find viable solutions for foreign armed-group elements who are ready to be disarmed and repatriated to their countries of origin. Special Envoy Xia will provide further details on the important work that has already been undertaken within the framework of that critical mechanism.

I would like to conclude by thanking the Council for its steadfast support for peace and stabilization efforts in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the region. I want to express my gratitude and appreciation to MONUSCO's leadership, and to the brave men and women on both the military and civilian sides of the Mission who continue to demonstrate an unwavering commitment to advancing their cause under the most trying circumstances.

The President: I thank Ms. Pobee for her briefing, and I now give the floor to Mr. Huang Xia.

Mr. Huang Xia (*spoke in French*): I am grateful for the opportunity to speak to the Security Council today, not long after my last briefing, just over a month ago (see S/PV.9023), in the light of the regrettably troubling situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the

Congo and its implications for the region. At the outset, I want to join Assistant Secretary-General Pobee in expressing my sincere condolences to the families of the victims of the recent attacks there and wishing a speedy recovery to the injured.

Almost 10 years ago, the devastating actions of the Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23) in and around Goma created a regional crisis, exacerbated by mutual accusations between the Democratic Republic of Congo and its neighbours. Sadly, it seems that history is now once again repeating itself. While this is a situation that we can only deplore, we must also do everything possible to prevent a new escalation and yet another crisis in the Great Lakes region, with potentially immeasurable humanitarian, security and political consequences. I therefore once again call on all armed groups in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo to stop the violence, immediately lay down their arms and engage resolutely in the Nairobi political dialogue process facilitated by Kenya. My Office and that of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo will continue to provide the technical and logistical support necessary to continue the peace process.

It goes without saying that we need a comprehensive approach to eradicating the presence of armed groups in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, especially in the context of the resurgence of the M-23 and persistent insecurity. And of course we can also understand that the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as the country primarily threatened by those armed groups, is determined to put a stop to it. However, as we have seen many times in the past, I firmly believe that the military option alone is not enough to bring about lasting peace in the region. I therefore want to reiterate the importance of the non-military measures that my Office has been trying to promote for some time. To that end, during the retreat of the operational cell of the Contact and Coordination Group that I mentioned in my last briefing, we developed a strategy for engaging with foreign armed groups and local communities that offers an approach designed to complement efforts to get the members of the groups to surrender and to gain the cooperation of the communities affected by the groups' activities. My Office will continue its efforts in that regard in close collaboration with the countries concerned.

Apart from the security aspects, it is now more important than ever for us to pursue our collective

political commitments. I therefore encourage the leaders of the region to continue their high-level dialogue on how to address the threat posed by the armed groups and prevent tensions from escalating between the Democratic Republic of the Congo and its neighbours. Dialogue between the leaders of the region concerned remains vital to ending those long-standing and deeply rooted problems once and for all. It is therefore crucial to continue mobilizing the existing bilateral and regional mechanisms, including the recent Nairobi Conclave process, the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region and, of course, the Addis Ababa Framework Agreement. In that regard, I want to commend President Uhuru Kenyatta of Kenya for his leadership, as well as the entire region — in fact, the African continent — for its commitment, as outlined by President Macky Sall of Senegal in his capacity as Chairperson of the African Union, to supporting the Democratic Republic of the Congo and its neighbours in their efforts to work together to find solutions to these long-standing problems.

In that context, tomorrow I will begin a new tour of the region in person, which, depending on the availability of those I am meeting with, should take me to all the countries concerned in the lead-up to the next Nairobi Conclave. I want to reiterate President Macky Sall's simple, three-pronged message to the countries of the region, which is that the region does not need a new crisis; we should keep the channels of dialogue open at all levels, including at the community level; and we should preserve the progress achieved in recent years through the various cooperation mechanisms. I would also like to reaffirm the commitment of the United Nations to supporting the countries of the region in finding peaceful and lasting solutions to the root causes of instability, as outlined in our regional strategy.

I would like to say a final word to the members of the Council. I know that they have to worry about many crises around the world, and I am pleased that the Great Lakes region has not been forgotten. As we all know, there is a genuine possibility that the recent increase in tensions could reverse the progress made in recent years in terms of dialogue and cooperation between the countries of the Great Lakes region, with potentially harmful consequences for civilian populations, particularly women and girls in the conflict zones of the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, who have already borne the brunt of decades of violence. As I said earlier, we must prevent that at all costs. All

of us, at the level of our individual countries and via our own diplomatic channels, must make every effort to encourage the countries of the region to maintain a continuing dialogue, even on the most difficult issues. That is the price of preventing the current crisis from worsening.

The President: I thank Mr. Xia for his briefing.

I would like to draw the attention of speakers to paragraph 22 of presidential note S/2017/507, which encourages all participants in Council meetings to deliver their statements in five minutes or less, in line with the Security Council's commitment to making more effective use of open meetings.

I now give the floor to those Council members wishing to make statements.

Mr. Kimani (Kenya): I have the pleasure to deliver this statement on behalf of the African members of the Security Council (A3), Kenya, Gabon and Ghana.

We welcome His Excellency Mr. Christophe Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, to New York. We thank him for his participation and appreciate his Government's commitment to seeking stability and security in the face of immense odds. We recognize that the fate of this gigantic country, bordering nine others and situated in the heart of Africa, will in many ways determine the future of our region. We also welcome the participation of representatives of neighbouring States in this meeting.

The A3 is encouraged by the positive regional developments in East and Central Africa. The admission of the Democratic Republic of the Congo into the East African Community (EAC) is a historic development. The EAC's convening in Nairobi of its second Regional Heads of State Conclave on the Democratic Republic of the Congo is a testament to the potential for regional integration to deliver hope for peace and security. At a time when the world is transitioning to green technology, the Democratic Republic of the Congo's membership in the EAC offers the opportunity to build a dynamic economic pole with a positive global impact. Peace and stability in the Democratic Republic of the Congo would mean decent employment and security for its people. It would enable a just global transition to green solutions powered by Congolese minerals that are extracted ethically and sustainably. The major

roadblock to that is the chronic and protracted insecurity in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. For that reason, the A3 commends the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo for commencing the inter-Congolese peace dialogue, facilitated by President Uhuru Kenyatta, in line with the outcomes of the second Regional Heads of State Conclave. We also welcome all the armed groups that are participating in the dialogue for their courage and commitment to a course of peace.

The briefing to be delivered by Mr. Christophe Lutundula Apala Pen'apala will further inform us about the inter-Congolese peace dialogue and its great potential. After many years of chronic insecurity and instability in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, it is an initiative that holds great promise. It is important that all the parties take ownership of the process and protect it. They must take advantage of the EAC's initiative and other mechanisms, such as the Economic Community of Central African States, the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region, the African Union and the United Nations.

The A3 remains deeply concerned about the dire security situation in the eastern provinces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We strongly condemn all armed groups operating in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the region and urge them to lay down their arms immediately. The armed groups, including the resurgent Mouvement du 23 mars, continue to exact a heavy toll on civilian and civilian objects. At least 35 people were killed last week in Djugu, in Ituri province, and Beni, in North Kivu province. Terrorist groups are also operating in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, including those affiliated with the Islamic State in Iraq and the Sham. Those groups regard the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo as fertile ground for recruitment and for generating wealth to carry out their operations around the world. We reiterate our call on all armed groups to participate unconditionally in the inter-Congolese peace dialogue in order to resolve their grievances, embrace the call for peace and pursue opportunities for prosperity by prioritizing participation in the country's development.

For its part, the United Nations and the international community should support the effective operationalization of the national Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme and work with the States of the region to find durable solutions for refugees and

internally displaced persons, including their voluntary, safe and dignified return and reintegration into their communities of origin.

In the light of the progressive drawdown and withdrawal of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), it is vital that the Security Council begin to take stock of the transfer of responsibilities to the Government. By strengthening its weapons and ammunition management system, in close cooperation with MONUSCO, the Government has shown a commitment to ensuring the control and monitoring of the weapons and ammunition in its possession. We therefore recommend that the Council respond favourably to the Congolese authorities' request to waive the notification requirement for the acquisition of weapons and reinforce its support in order to address the illicit proliferation and supply of weapons via trans-border criminal networks.

There is no question that poverty is both a root cause and a driver of conflict and instability. Regrettably, the people of the Democratic Republic of the Congo have continued to languish in poverty despite their abundant natural resources. The A3 encourages the countries of the region to implement their commitments, which include establishing and activating internal systems of control, monitoring and verification in order to eliminate the illicit mineral trade. We further encourage them to recommit to strengthening and implementing regional frameworks aimed at creating a peaceful environment conducive to achieving a secure and prosperous region. In the same breath, we encourage dialogue among the countries of the region, with a view to addressing any issues related to mutual security concerns and defusing any tensions that could undermine the ongoing peace efforts.

We commend the efforts of MONUSCO and international partners to promote peace and security in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We reiterate our appreciation to the Secretary-General of the United Nations and the Chairperson of the African Union, as well as all regional and global leaders, for their support for the inter-Congolese peace dialogue. The A3 and France have presented a draft presidential statement for the Council's consideration in that regard, and we thank members for their robust engagement. We hope to see a strong endorsement from the Council of that initiative. In conclusion, the A3 reaffirms its commitment to the

sovereignty, independence and territorial integrity of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Mr. De Rivière (France) (*spoke in French*): I would like to thank all the briefers and to welcome the participation in this meeting of the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as the representatives of Rwanda and Uganda. I want to highlight three points.

First, in the context of ongoing developments that are a threat to the entire region, the Nairobi process is an initiative that gives reason to hope. The situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo is worrying. The armed groups are committing more frequent attacks. The Mouvement du 23 mars is resurgent, and its violent attacks are threatening the stability of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. The Allied Democratic Forces continues to pose a major threat in the area, and as always, its primary victims are civilians. France therefore calls on all the armed groups to stop the fighting, and for eligible groups to participate in the discussions initiated in Nairobi, without conditions. Operationalizing the new Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme is essential if that process is to move forward. It must be adapted at the provincial level to reintegrate combatants who have chosen peace into their communities. France therefore calls on international partners, in particular the World Bank, to support its implementation as soon as possible. At the same time, efforts must also be made to combat the re-emergence of hate speech.

Any potential regional force that may be established must act coherently and in coordination with the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO). There are already many actors on the ground. All States must act together to fight the destructive forces in full respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Secondly, France calls on all States in the region to continue a dialogue in order to build confidence. The most recent summit of the Regional Monitoring Mechanism of the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region, held in Kinshasa, reaffirmed that objective. In acting to reduce tensions, States must be guided by the letter and spirit of the Addis

Ababa Framework Agreement. As the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Rwanda have requested, it is vital to ensure that the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism of the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region can shed light on the recent cross-border bombings.

Cooperation should be front and centre in the fight to stop the looting of the Democratic Republic of the Congo's natural resources. Efforts must be redoubled in order to ensure that minerals are certified and supply chains transparent. Only fair and sustainable exploitation of the resources of the Democratic Republic of the Congo will benefit its people. The same spirit of dialogue should be applied in order to accelerate the implementation of the Nairobi Declaration on Justice and Good Governance. A regional framework for judicial cooperation must be developed in order to combat the criminal groups that are fuelling instability, and a national strategy for transitional justice must finally be operationalized in order to combat impunity and promote reconciliation.

My third and final point is that France and the European Union will continue to support the region on its path to peace. More than a year after the eruption of Mount Nyiragongo, the humanitarian emergency continues. Insecurity is exacerbating the people's needs. The response from the country's partners is being hindered by attacks on humanitarian personnel. Their work to help the population must be protected, and the United Nations agencies, funds and programmes must also speed up their deployment to the provinces where MONUSCO is no longer present to protect the gains that have been made. France will strengthen its commitment. Between now and 2025, our development agency will mobilize half a billion euros in support of the health of the Congolese people, their agriculture and women's empowerment. We will continue to strengthen the Congolese security forces through our support to the Kinshasa War School and the training we provide to Congolese battalions. The European Union will also remain mobilized, providing €400 million to support the Democratic Republic of the Congo between 2021 and 2024. I am referring in particular to its United for Gender Equality programme, which will provide €20 million to continue the fight against sexual violence.

The Democratic Republic of the Congo and its neighbours hold the future of the Great Lakes in their hands. France will support the choice of peace.

Ms. Byrne Nason (Ireland) (*spoke in French*): I would like to thank Assistant Secretary-General Pobee and Special Envoy of the Secretary-General Xia for their briefings this afternoon and to recognize the presence of His Excellency the Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, whom we welcome.

Our discussion is timely in the wake of the developments in the eastern Democratic Republic of Congo and the region over the past few weeks. Today I would like to address three points — the deteriorating conflict, the tragic humanitarian situation and the importance of regional cooperation, which are closely related to the need for a consistent response to the current conflict in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Ireland is extremely concerned about the increased rate of violence and insecurity, especially as perpetrated by the Allied Democratic Forces (ADF), the Coopérative pour le développement du Congo and the resurgent Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23). I reiterate our condemnation of the attacks by the M-23 a week ago on the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO) and the positions of the Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo (FARDC). I also condemn in the strongest terms the attacks over the past weekend committed by the ADF, which resulted in the deaths of 27 civilians. Those attacks are happening in the context of ongoing violence and attacks by armed groups against civilians in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, including by targeting the most vulnerable populations in camps for internally displaced persons. We call on all actors to end that violence and the human rights violations and abuses, as well as the violations of international humanitarian law.

(*spoke in English*)

The humanitarian situation is extremely worrying. Conflict is contributing to hunger and generating staggering levels of food insecurity and malnutrition, as well as increased forced migration and displacement. All too often, we see that this can lead to greater risk for women and girls, including the risk of sexual and gender-based violence.

Trust, transparency and cooperation will be fundamental to resolving the conflict that has plagued the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo for so long. MONUSCO, working with the FARDC,

has done much to address the threat posed by armed groups in the region. But no stakeholder can solve that challenge unilaterally, nor can the solution be found in military action alone. Regional cooperation should be strengthened, including through the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region and the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region. A comprehensive strategy for security-sector reform is required, as is a strengthened justice system and renewed efforts to fight impunity. Women's inclusion and meaningful participation is essential across all those efforts.

Ireland commends the recent positive developments in the Great Lakes region as its leaders work to de-escalate tension, build confidence and advance regional cooperation. Regional economic cooperation and integration will clearly be key to lasting peace in the region, and the positive signs of progress are there. The recent meeting of the Heads of State Conclave on the Democratic Republic of the Congo is further evidence of the commitment of countries in the region to working together to promote regional peace and security. The Conclave has set in motion necessary discussions between the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the armed groups, and we hope that this can lead to sustained and sustainable peace in the eastern part of the country. It is now vital to ensure that the armed groups participate unconditionally in the political process and cease all violence that could undermine the dialogue.

To support that, the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Reintegration and Stabilization programme must be fit for purpose, with the ability to be scaled up rapidly as required. For that to happen, the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo will need adequate and timely support from partners. While the establishment of the Nairobi peace process has given cause for hope, worsening violence could quickly cause those tentative efforts to unravel. All parties involved in the Conclave must work together to build a sustainable peace.

The politicization of instability must not deepen the current crisis. Regional partners must ensure that efforts are made to de-escalate tensions, build trust and collaborate, as they will be crucial to ensuring the success of the Nairobi process. Ireland therefore urges for sustained regional cooperation in responding to the challenges posed by armed-group activity in the

eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. We hope that the political process now under way will build trust and establish channels of communication that will ultimately help deliver peace and prosperity to the people of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the wider region.

Mrs. Alhefeiti (United Arab Emirates): At the outset, I would like to thank Assistant Secretary-General Martha Pobe and Mr. Huang Xia, the Special Envoy of the Secretary-General, for their invaluable briefings. I would also like to welcome to the Council His Excellency Christophe Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as the Permanent Representatives of Rwanda and Uganda.

The United Arab Emirates appreciates the convening of this meeting to hear about recent initiatives aimed at promoting dialogue to address the persistent challenges in the region, and we commend the efforts by the leaders of the East African Community countries to maintain peace and stability in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the entire region. We also affirm the importance of the continued commitment of the signatories to the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region to addressing the threats posed by all armed groups in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. We reiterate the Security Council's call to all stakeholders to engage constructively in the political process on the Democratic Republic of the Congo launched in Nairobi by the Heads of the States of the region, where the focus should continue to be on political dialogue for achieving a sustainable and comprehensive peace.

In line with the Security Council's recent press statement (SC/14903) condemning the attacks by all armed groups in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, we stress the importance of holding accountable all who target civilians and United Nations peacekeeping missions and of ensuring the safety and security of peacekeeping forces. The attacks remind us of the urgent need to address the complex and interrelated security challenges facing the Democratic Republic of the Congo, particularly in its eastern regions, if sustainable peace is to be achieved.

In conclusion, we affirm our full commitment to supporting the United Nations Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which is an

important partner in the maintenance of stability in the region, including through its continued cooperation with the Government on the transition plan for the period from 2021 to 2023. In the context of its implementation, we stress the importance of preserving and building on the gains achieved so far, particularly in the area of regional diplomacy.

Additionally, it will be critical to continue efforts to empower women and young people and to maintain a regional, political and security environment conducive to achieving stability and contributing to building resilient societies. The United Arab Emirates looks forward to continuing to work with the Democratic Republic of the Congo and with all Member States to achieve those goals.

Mr. Kariuki (United Kingdom): Let me begin by offering a warm welcome to the Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Mr. Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, as well as the representatives of Rwanda and Uganda. I would also like to thank Assistant Secretary-General Pobee and Special Envoy Huang Xia for their briefings.

I will focus my statement on the security and humanitarian situations in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo and the ongoing regional efforts to pursue peace.

The United Kingdom remains deeply concerned about the fragile security situation in the eastern part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. The latest recurrence of violence threatens recent efforts to pursue peace. In particular, we note the deep and understandable anger of countries in the region about alleged cross-border attacks. The United Kingdom would like to point to the impact that decades of violence in the Great Lakes have had on the lives and futures of the people of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the wider region. The Council cannot become hardened to the displacement of more than 5 million people, or to serious and sustained violations and abuses of human rights and international humanitarian law.

The United Kingdom welcomes the recent enhanced diplomatic outreach and dialogue between countries in the region. The region's leaders, convened by President Kenyatta, have shown the statesmanship their people deserve. We also welcome the engagement of the African Union and regional mechanisms. It is clear that there are many actors in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the wider region who would be happy to

see such regional determination to deliver peace fail. In that context, we call on the leaders of the region to redouble their efforts to pursue dialogue, de-escalation and the use of effective regional mechanisms to resolve disputes. We also reiterate our call to all the armed groups operating in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo to immediately cease their violence and participate unconditionally in the ongoing political process in Nairobi.

High levels of violence and insecurity, perpetuated in particular by the armed groups of the Allied Democratic Forces, the Coopérative pour le développement du Congo and the Mouvement du 23 mars, are hampering humanitarian access and putting the lives of a highly vulnerable population at risk. Similarly, the continued kidnappings of humanitarian staff in the Sake-Masisi area mean that vital assistance is not reaching those in greatest need. We urge the Government to take concrete action against criminality in the area and to ensure the protection of humanitarian workers.

We are also concerned about the risk posed to civilians by intercommunal violence, particularly in camps for internally displaced persons in Ituri province. A sustainable plan for their protection is desperately needed. In that regard, it is vital to ensure strong coordination and a supportive relationship with the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO) in order to sustain security and the protection of civilians. That will be particularly important as MONUSCO prepares to withdraw from Tanganyika province and focus its efforts on the conflict-affected provinces of North and South Kivu and Ituri. We see that as a moment of both hope and real risk for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the wider region. The United Kingdom stands with all who seek a more peaceful future for the people of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the region.

Ms. Juul (Norway): I would like to thank Assistant Secretary-General Pobee and Special Envoy Huang Xia for their informative briefings. I would also like to warmly welcome the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as the representatives of Uganda and Rwanda, to our meeting today.

Let me start by condemning the recent attacks in North Kivu by the Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23) on the Forces armées de la République démocratique

du Congo and the troops of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. Deliberate attacks on those trying to secure stability are unacceptable and the perpetrators must be held accountable. We are also deeply concerned about the situation for civilians in the eastern part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, including in areas where the Allied Democratic Forces and the *Coopérative pour le développement du Congo* continue to attack the civilian population. Full, safe and unhindered humanitarian access is crucial to protecting and assisting those in need.

Norway urges all parties to respect and comply with their human rights and international humanitarian law obligations. We call on all armed groups, including the M-23, to participate unconditionally in the consultation process initiated by the second Regional Heads of State Conclave for the Democratic Republic of the Congo. It is also crucial that eligible armed groups lay down their weapons and participate in the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme so as to reduce the security threat to civilians in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo and lay the foundations for social and economic development.

The root causes of conflict must be addressed if we are to end the violence and protect the civilian population in the eastern areas of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. A lack of protection fuels conflict, displacement and mistrust. In addition to implementing the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme, challenges such as the lack of security-sector reform, impunity and the illicit trade in natural resources must be addressed. Some of those issues are cross-border in nature, and Norway therefore welcomes efforts to strengthen regional cooperation. The second Regional Heads of State Conclave, convened in April, was an important step in that regard. The broadest possible participation should now be sought. Follow-up on the decisions made at the Conclave will be important to promoting peace in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and we thank Kenya for its leadership, as well as the countries in the region for their commitment to the process.

We are concerned about the recent tensions between Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and we urge all parties to participate in constructive dialogue to improve relations among the countries of

the region. We also welcome the readiness of some of the armed groups to participate in that process.

Finally, the Democratic Republic of the Congo's admission into the East African Community will also enable closer cooperation between the countries of the region. That can promote trust and reduce cross-border threats to stability, with benefits for the Congolese people. The people in the conflict-affected areas of the Democratic Republic of the Congo have suffered for too long. Norway reiterates its support for all efforts that can contribute to stabilization and sustainable peace.

Mr. Spasse (Albania): At the outset, I would like to welcome His Excellency Mr. Christophe Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as the representatives of Rwanda and Uganda. I thank Ms. Pobe and Mr. Huang Xia for their briefings and the three African members of the Council for calling for this timely meeting.

Since our last meeting on the situation in the Democratic Republic of the Congo in March (see S/PV.9007), the latest developments at both the national and regional levels have become even more alarming. We saw some positive signs that have unfortunately failed to trigger a positive change in the situation. It is sad to acknowledge that our expectations and those of the Congolese people have been disappointed once again.

I will focus on two topics, the first of which is the security situation. On 24 May, the Council issued a press statement condemning the attack on the positions in North Kivu of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO) and the *Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo* (FARDC) by the *Mouvement du 23 mars* (M-23). Albania condemns all attacks by all armed groups, including the Allied Democratic Forces, the *Coopérative pour le développement du Congo* and especially the M-23, which has made a robust comeback with sophisticated and strategic attacks and in a surprisingly short amount of time has shown a formidable ability to organize and equip itself with heavy weapons.

The human rights situation is still a source of great alarm. We remain deeply concerned about the human suffering caused by the ongoing heavy fighting among the M-23, the FARDC and MONUSCO. Almost 15,000 people have been internally displaced, and more

than 11,000 have crossed the border into Uganda. It is also alarming that, due to the growing insecurity, the distribution of humanitarian assistance is subject to partial disruptions despite the brave efforts of humanitarian partners striving to keep humanitarian access open. We continue to call for an immediate end to the violence and for all stakeholders to engage in constructive dialogue and allow for unhindered humanitarian access.

We are all aware that the recent attacks could seriously undermine the fragile situation that we have obtained thus far. The implications could be devastating not only for the Democratic Republic of the Congo, but also for the entire region. Albania is extremely worried by the latest reports of fighting along the border between the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Rwanda. We therefore urge all stakeholders to commit themselves to implementing the decisions adopted at the Nairobi meetings.

That leads me to my second point — regional diplomacy. Efforts must be stepped up to give true political traction to the Nairobi process, in keeping with the commitment made by the signatories to the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region to address the threat posed by all armed groups active in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Negotiations with those groups must continue in an inclusive and transparent manner to enable the seeds of peace to grow. Albania reiterates its call for eligible armed groups to lay down their weapons through the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization Programme, while urging the Congolese Government and its international partners to provide adequate resources for the Programme's effective implementation.

Of course, no disarmament, demobilization and reintegration programme can really be effective without addressing the underlying root causes of conflict. We call on the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the countries of the region to redouble their efforts to minimize the revenues that armed groups gain from the exploitation of natural resources. We call on the authorities of the Democratic Republic of the Congo to engage in the fight against impunity, regardless of the group or armed force to which perpetrators belong. Once again, Albania reiterates that accountability is crucial to healing the wounds caused by conflict.

Lastly, I would like to commend MONUSCO for its work, together with the FARDC, in successfully addressing the latest offensives by the M-23, while noting that the situation is still precarious near Goma. We must be vigilant; the threat is far from over. In addition, for MONUSCO to fulfil its mandate, it must be guaranteed the appropriate logistical support.

Mr. Dai Bing (China) (*spoke in Chinese*) I thank Assistant Secretary-General Pobee and Special Envoy Xia Huang for their briefings. I welcome His Excellency Mr. Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and the Permanent Representatives of Rwanda and Uganda to this meeting.

The recent deteriorating security situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo is deeply troubling. Armed groups continue to attack civilians, causing massive casualties and displacement. Since last March, the Mouvement du 23 mars has resumed its military activities and exchanged fire with the Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo several times. The United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO) has also been under attack, leading to the tragic deaths of many peacekeepers.

China expresses its concern over the fierce clash in North Kivu last week. We support the swift issuance of a press statement by the Security Council (SC/14903), condemning it and urging all armed groups to lay down their weapons immediately and unconditionally and participate in the political process initiated by countries of the region in Nairobi. At the same time, we have also taken note of the statement by Rwanda on 23 May, which contains the decision to refer the relevant matter to the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism of the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region.

We welcome the communication between the Governments of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Rwanda on the latest developments. China supports the African Union and other regional organizations in promoting dialogue among countries of the region to ease tensions.

Given the close linkage between the security situations in the Great Lakes region, maintaining dialogue and cooperation among countries of the region is an effective way to address common security concerns and challenges and reduce cross-border security incidents. China commends the countries of

the region for reaffirming their commitment to the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region, and welcomes the launch of the two-track political and security process by the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Kenya, Burundi, Uganda and Rwanda at the Regional Heads of State Conclave, held in Nairobi at the end of April. We note that, under the facilitation of Kenya, the Democratic Republic of the Congo held two rounds of dialogue with armed groups. We look forward to the briefings by Mr. Lutundula Apala Pen'apala and the African members of the Council on relevant developments and their expectations of the Security Council and the United Nations. We call on the international community to support the efforts by countries of the region to resolve African issues in African ways and encourage MONUSCO and the Special Envoy to strengthen communication with such countries.

There is no simple military solution to eliminating the root causes of conflict in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the region. An integrated approach must be taken. The Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo should improve its governance capacity, advance reforms in key sectors, implement disarmament and demobilization programmes and deliver the dividends of socioeconomic development to ordinary people. Only by doing that can the Government achieve effective control over the eastern region. To resolve the problem of the illegal exploitation of, and trade in, natural resources, military means alone is not enough. The key is to achieve mutual benefits and win-win results through regional cooperation and turn common development into the basis for regional peace and stability. The international community should help the Democratic Republic of the Congo and countries of the region to address the humanitarian challenges and advance peace, development and humanitarian work in an integrated manner. China appreciates the Special Envoy's support to the countries of the region in resolving regional issues through non-military means, and we encourage the Office of the Special Envoy to work closely with such countries to implement the new United Nations strategy and action plans for the Great Lakes region.

China stands ready to continue its active role in supporting the efforts of the Democratic Republic of the Congo to achieve its sovereignty, territorial integrity and national security.

Mr. Tirumurti (India): Let me begin by thanking Assistant Secretary-General Pobe and the Special Envoy of the Secretary-General for the Great Lakes Region, Mr. Huang Xia, for their briefings on the political and security developments concerning the situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. I welcome the presence of the Honourable Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the representatives of Rwanda and Uganda at today's meeting.

The situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo has been worsening in the recent months, with the increasing activities of armed groups. That deteriorating situation risks undermining the political process currently under way. The Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo (FARDC), with the support of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), have been making efforts to address the threat posed by armed groups. However, the Mouvement du 23 mars has been making significant inroads. We strongly condemn attacks perpetrated by armed groups against civilians, security forces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and peacekeepers.

That has put enormous pressure on the FARDC in discharging its primary responsibility to protect civilians. The Security Council must acknowledge that MONUSCO's role is supportive and not aimed at replacing the FARDC. As such, there is an urgent need to match and enhance the FARDC's capacities to take on the robust fire-power of the armed groups. That gap cannot, and should not, be bridged by a creative interpretation of MONUSCO's mandate. We need to ensure that each of MONUSCO's contingents is equipped and undertakes only mandated tasks. In that regard, we recall the provisions of paragraph 29, sub-paragraph (i) (e), of resolution 2612 (2021). We also need to ensure that the safety and security of peacekeepers is not compromised under any circumstances.

The solution to the complex nature of the problem in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo cannot be found solely through military means. In that context, we welcome and support the two-track road map agreed at the second Regional Heads of State Conclave, held in Nairobi earlier this year.

We also note the commitment shown by the leadership of countries in the region to resolve

outstanding issues through dialogue. The call of the international community on all armed groups to lay down their arms and commit to the peace process needs to be followed up proactively.

It is imperative that links to the sustenance of armed groups be broken at the source. We have long been discussing how the illegal exploitation of, and trade in, natural resources in the eastern part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo have fuelled armed groups' activities. Several reports by the Panel of Experts have described the mechanism in much detail. Greater commitment by the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the region will be needed to ensure that the mines are protected, regulations are strengthened and regional partnerships are further bolstered.

The Khartoum conference has provided a useful framework and direction for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the region. The political leadership in the region has an extremely important role to play in seeking solutions through dialogue. Equally important is to ensure that MONUSCO be allowed to carry out its mandate within the framework of what has been agreed by the Security Council.

Mr. Gómez Robledo Verduzco (Mexico) (*spoke in Spanish*): My delegation thanks the Assistant Secretary-General for Africa and the Special Envoy of the Secretary-General for the Great Lakes Region for the information that they have shared with us this afternoon. My delegation is also grateful for the convening of this meeting in the light of the regrettable deterioration of the security situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. I welcome the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the delegations of Rwanda and Uganda, which are joining us.

Mexico expresses its concern about the increase in the activity of armed groups in the eastern part of the country and strongly condemns the deliberately targeted attacks by the Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23) against the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO). Attacks against the personnel of peacekeeping operations are unacceptable and, in this case, may constitute war crimes. It is imperative that those responsible be brought to justice and tried so that those crimes do not go unpunished and are not repeated.

Of equal concern are the recent clashes between the M-23 and the Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo. That escalation in violence is in addition to the attacks carried out by Coopérative pour le développement du Congo against camps for displaced persons and the incursions by the Allied Democratic Forces. All of that has further exacerbated the humanitarian situation. As the Special Envoy just informed us, more than 72,000 people have been displaced in the past few days alone, and a total of 170,000 persons have been displaced since November 2021.

The increase in violence has also had serious consequences for humanitarian access. We once again call for ramping up the security of humanitarian distribution routes and for all parties involved to facilitate safe and unhindered access for humanitarian personnel and teams carrying out that critical work. Regional cooperation is key to addressing the root causes of instability, from the illegal exploitation of natural resources to the common threat posed by armed groups.

Dialogue and the mechanisms provided for by regional and subregional organizations and the Intergovernmental Authority on Development, as well as the continued support of African Union, must be prioritized. In that regard, we welcome the commitment of the Heads of State to implement a two-track approach to find a solution to the security situation in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which was adopted at the most recent Heads of State Conclave on the Democratic Republic of the Congo, hosted by the Chairperson of the East African Community.

In that regard, we welcome the fact that Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo have availed themselves of the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism, thereby prioritizing dialogue.

The resurgence of the M-23, however, highlights the urgency — as has already been raised on several occasions in the Security Council — of implementing the national disarmament, demobilization, community reintegration and stabilization programme. We are convinced that such programmes are a critical tool for stabilization and peacebuilding.

But disarmament is not enough. The international community must also spare no effort to halt arms trafficking, which continues to fuel cycles of violence, and Mexico has urged, and will continue to urge, such

efforts. At the same time, priority must be given to providing socioeconomic opportunities to demobilized persons in order to prevent them from being recruited again. A comprehensive approach is therefore key to moving towards sustainable peace.

In conclusion, Mexico reiterates its support for diplomatic efforts in the region and the need to address the root causes of violence. Otherwise, it will be impossible to achieve sustainable peace.

Ms. Evstigneeva (Russian Federation) (*spoke in Russian*): We thank Assistant Secretary-General Martha Ama Akyaa Pobee and Special Envoy of the Secretary-General Huang Xia for their briefings. We welcome the participation at this meeting of the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Mr. Christophe Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, and the representatives of Rwanda and Uganda.

Like other Security Council members, we are extremely concerned about the grave outbreak of hostilities in the eastern part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We hope that the Congolese armed forces, together with United Nations peacekeepers and international partners, will be able to swiftly re-establish control over the security situation and prevent any further escalation of violence.

We would like to call special attention to the fact that the armed forces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Blue Helmets of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo are valiantly carrying out their duties. They risk their lives every day for peace in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo.

The immediate priority today is to end hostilities and begin dialogue, as it is impossible to achieve normalization in the Democratic Republic of the Congo by military measures alone. We call on illegal armed groups to cease their attacks, reject the use of violence and negotiate with the Congolese Government. A ceasefire must be followed by measures and steps that would lead to a genuine change in the situation. We believe that frank and constructive interaction among the States of the region should play a key role in advancing long-term settlement and reconciliation.

It is important to refrain from confrontational rhetoric, overcome persistent mutual distrust and disagreement and support and facilitate the development

of the processes that have been initiated, and are continuing, within the Nairobi framework. Every effort must be made to transform the commitment to dialogue of the countries neighbouring the Democratic Republic of the Congo into practical cooperation in order to achieve stability. That is, of course, in the interests of all the countries of the region and of the international community.

We must not allow the repetition of the bloody events of previous years or an escalation into large-scale hostilities, which would again affect the region and whose consequences all of us, above all the citizens of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, would have to deal with for decades to come.

In practical terms, we believe that it is important to make full use of the tools of the Regional Oversight Mechanism of the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region. In addition, we need to concentrate our efforts on developing and implementing disarmament, demobilization and social reintegration programmes for former combatants, which would significantly increase the number of those willing to leave the ranks of armed groups once and for all.

The Congolese population has suffered from violence and armed conflict for far too long. People need to have hope for peace and for a normal life.

We do hope that with the assistance from the United Nations, States of the region and the international community, Kinshasa will be able to curb the recent acute threats and reorient the Democratic Republic of the Congo towards the tasks of nation-building and socioeconomic development. That is particularly important in view of the presidential elections planned for late 2023. These elections are to become a key stage in stabilizing the country.

Mr. De Almeida Filho (Brazil): I would like to thank Ms. Martha Pobee and Mr. Huang Xia for their informative briefings. I would also like to welcome the Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and the delegations of Rwanda and Uganda, to the Security Council.

In recent months, the Council has been witnessing a continuously deteriorating security and humanitarian situation in the eastern part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. I would briefly recall some events: the

savage attack on the Savo camp for internally displaced persons in Ituri province by the *Coopérative pour le développement du Congo* militias; the crash of a helicopter belonging to the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO) in North Kivu province; the murder of a Nepali peacekeeper also in Ituri; and the attacks by the *Mouvement du 23 mars* (M-23) on MONUSCO and the Armed Forces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. The disturbing frequency of these events is a mere fraction of the episodes of violence that bedevil the population of the affected parts of the Democratic Republic.

Even more worrisome is the fact that, against the best expectations and all efforts of the authorities of the United Nations and of countries in the region, the situation seems to be getting worse. The report of the Secretary-General on MONUSCO (S/2022/252), dated 21 March, ominously noted that there were indications that the illegal M-23 armed group seemed to have resurfaced. As we can now well see, that group does not hesitate to attack United Nations peacekeepers.

Brazil wishes to commend the efforts of the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which has embraced such ambitious initiatives as the new Demobilization, Disarmament, Community Recovery and Stabilization Programme for ex-combatants, launched last March. More important still are the initiatives aimed at cooperation with neighbouring countries, such as the increased coordination in the security domain with Uganda and, particularly, the peace negotiations hosted by Kenya.

The conflict in the eastern Democratic Republic has regional roots. Regional cooperation is therefore key to addressing it properly. It must be noted, however, that all efforts made by the authorities of the Democratic Republic will achieve long-lasting results only if the underlying causes of conflict are addressed by fostering development and political participation of the population in the affected areas.

The long-standing state of siege in certain provinces raises concerns, as do episodes of violence attributed to the armed forces, which will be duly investigated. Moreover, cooperation with neighbouring States can produce the desired results only if the sovereignty of the Democratic Republic is fully respected; otherwise, it risks further inflaming the volatile situation around the Great Lakes.

Along with increased regional cooperation, fostering coordination between MONUSCO and the Armed Forces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo has produced positive results. The fact that MONUSCO has faced attacks in recent months is not a reason to reduce but rather to step up those coordination efforts.

We have recently celebrated the International Day of United Nations Peacekeepers. No less than 24 MONUSCO men and women were awarded the Dag Hammarskjöld Medal last week. This is but a small tribute to the immense efforts made by the personnel to further the mandate established by the Security Council. This year alone, military personnel from Nepal, Pakistan, Russia and Serbia have paid the ultimate price. We take this occasion to pay tribute to them.

The President: I shall now make a statement in my capacity as the representative of the United States.

Let me start by thanking briefers Assistant Secretary-General Pobee and Special Envoy Xia for their remarks. I would like to welcome Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs Lutundula Apala Pen'apala, whose presence in the Chamber today is appreciated. We also welcome the Permanent Representatives of Rwanda and Uganda to this conversation.

I greatly appreciate Foreign Minister Lutundula Apala Pen'apala's traveling to be with us in the Security Council today. The United States values President Tshisekedi Tshilombo's commitment to strengthening the Democratic Republic of the Congo's democracy and human rights, as well as the Government's efforts to fight corruption and protect the environment. President Tshisekedi Tshilombo can count on the continued support of the United States for these efforts through our Privileged Partnership for Peace, Prosperity and Preservation of the Environment.

We recognize that his Government and the country's security forces face enormous challenges to stability, particularly in North and South Kivu and Ituri provinces. We also recognize the urgency reflected by the Foreign Minister's coming to address the Council in this Chamber today to work to end the decades-long suffering of the people of the eastern part of the Democratic Republic, who deserve peace. To that end, we applaud the diplomatic efforts of the Nairobi peace talks and the pursuit of lasting peace in the region. We

also support the efforts of the African Union Chair calling for peace.

We take note of the Democratic Republic of the Congo recently joining the East Africa Community (EAC). Our colleagues, the three African members of the Council, last month described the EAC as

“one of the world’s most extensive exercises in the integration of trade, investment and the free movement of people” (*S/PV.9023, p. 11*).

We believe that the members of the EAC have a pivotal role to play in ensuring both the prosperity and stability of the region.

In the face of heightened security challenges that the Democratic Republic of the Congo faces, including but not limited to attacks by the Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23) in North Kivu and the influx of refugees from the Democratic Republic into Uganda in recent weeks, we are encouraged that the Armed Forces of the Democratic Republic of the Congo have collaborated effectively with the forces of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo to contain the various armed groups terrorizing civilian populations in the east. We are concerned by reports of cross-border attacks on both sides of the border between the Democratic Republic and Rwanda in recent weeks, and we urge the two Governments to engage in dialogue to reduce tension and pursue a diplomatic resolution.

We further urge all actors to prioritize civilian protection. The Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo should continue dialogue with neighbouring countries, especially with regard to the M-23’s ongoing campaign of violence against the civilian population.

The eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo needs effective regional coordination. It demands the demobilization, disarmament and community-based reintegration of eligible members of armed groups. It necessitates the protection of civilians and respect for human rights, and it supports ensuring that the benefits of the Democratic Republic’s extraordinary resources are enjoyed by the people of the country. It also requires accountability for those who have abused and violated those rights. When these needs are fulfilled, peace will be achieved. We look forward to working with the Democratic Republic of the Congo and other partners to that end.

I now resume my functions as President of the Council.

I give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Lutundula Apala Pen’apala, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Mr. Lutundula Apala Pen’apala (Democratic Republic of the Congo) (*spoke in French*): It is a great honour for me to address the Security Council today, Tuesday, 31 May, here in the Chamber, the place where decisions that determine the fate of nations and the way the world works are made, in order to discuss the security and political situation in my country, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which has become a hotspot in Africa owing to insecurity, massacres, the systematic pillaging of our national wealth and widespread human rights violations perpetrated for what will soon be 28 years by armed groups in the eastern areas of the country, and now especially in Ituri, North Kivu and South Kivu provinces.

However, before getting into the substance of things, on behalf of our President, Mr. Félix-Antoine Tshisekedi Tshilombo, and the members of the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, I want to express our warm greetings to you, Madam President, Ambassador Linda Thomas-Greenfield of the United States of America, whose mandate at the head of the Security Council comes to an end today. I would like to congratulate you, Madam, on the wisdom and skill with which you have led this strategically important United Nations body this month, and to sincerely thank you for organizing this meeting. We are also grateful to Secretary-General António Guterres for his sustained attention to the security situation in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which he has been to a number of times and where he has visited the problem areas to see the realities on the ground for himself despite his very busy schedule. The Democratic Republic of the Congo remains committed to the values of civilization defended by the United Nations and to strictly implementing the provisions of its Charter, as well as to achieving its noble goals for the welfare of all of humankind, which is the reason the United Nations was established.

I also want to take this opportunity to reiterate the gratitude of the Congolese people to our global Organization for remaining at their side throughout the dark moments of their history that have occurred since

the country's accession to national and international sovereignty, with the aim of resolving the recurrent crises that have marked our struggle for national independence, democracy, the rule of law, stability, security and socioeconomic development. In that regard, the United Nations action in the Democratic Republic of the Congo over the past 20 years, first through the United Nations Organization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and then through the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), regardless of what some might think, has been crucial and decisive in avoiding the worst and committing the country to a path of institutional development. It will always be a part of the collective memory of the Congolese people.

The United Nations is one of the guarantors of the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region, signed in Addis Ababa in 2013. The United Nations is also an important strategic partner for my country and one of those working hardest on the ground to restore security, peace, stability and development in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. Given the special status of the United Nations in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and its unwavering involvement with our country, the President and the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo believe it is important to inform the Security Council of the ongoing efforts to restore peace and security in our country and in the Great Lakes region in general.

In that regard, we want to emphasize that on 8 April the Democratic Republic of the Congo was granted entry to the East African Community, a natural development in line with our geography, history, blood relations and cultural and trade links between the Congolese people and other members of the Community. The integration of the Democratic Republic of the Congo in the East African Community is also part of a national strategic development approach that involves pooling economic assets, sharing markets, ensuring the flow and control of goods and persons between the Democratic Republic of the Congo and its neighbours, the realization of integrated projects and our shared struggle against insecurity, terrorism and destabilization in the subregion. The Democratic Republic of the Congo is grateful to the countries of the East African Community that facilitated its entry, and especially to President Uhuru Muigai Kenyatta of

Kenya, the current Chairperson of the East African Community, who promoted this effort. From now on, the Democratic Republic of the Congo is part of the East African Community.

On 21 April President Kenyatta took the initiative to bring together our President and the Heads of State of Uganda and Rwanda in Nairobi, joined later by the President of Burundi, in order to consider the security situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo and among our neighbours. Following the second Conclave, on 21 April, the five Heads of State, in accordance with articles 5, 6 and 24 of the Treaty for the Establishment of the East African Community, agreed on a plan aimed at resolving the security crisis in our eastern areas and the region. They urged their counterparts among the other member States of the East African Community to join them and agreed to invite the involvement at that stage of the United States, France, the African Union, the United Nations and the East African Community, as well as the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region (ICGLR), as observers at the Nairobi process. That group has been expanded to include the five permanent members of the Security Council, the European Union and the Southern African Development Community (SADC).

The peace process is currently based on two tracks. First, for President Tshisekedi the political approach involves extending a hand to the local armed groups, specifically through consultations on peace and security, in Ituri, North Kivu and South Kivu provinces. Members of the armed groups who are unwilling to accept the President's offer will be considered negative entities to be neutralized by armed forces. President Kenyatta is leading the political track, with three goals. The first is to express the President's willingness to extend his hand of to all his fellow citizens and to communicate his call for unconditional disarmament. The second is to listen to the representatives of the armed groups and communities in order to identify the political and institutional efforts needed to establish the necessary trust, restore the State's authority and support disarmament, while also recalling the intangible and non-negotiable principles of the national Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Reintegration and Stabilization programme, which are that there will be no systematic integration of combatants into the army and no amnesty, and that the reintegration of combatants into their communities of origin will be a priority. Finally, it aims to serve as a warning to recalcitrant

combatants that disarmament is not optional. It will be voluntary but, if necessary, it will be enforced by the military, as the Heads of State have agreed. Secondly, force will be used for national and foreign groups that do not respond positively to their leaders' appeals for military neutralization. The leaders of all the countries concerned were asked to make corresponding efforts to set up consultations and approaches with the armed groups within their own territories. In that regard, the decision was taken to accelerate the implementation of an East African Community regional force, to be tasked with monitoring those negative forces and, if necessary, combating them. While the military track is under the able leadership of President Félix-Antoine Tshisekedi Tshilombo, I can assure the Council that for now, the political track that the State is pursuing should ensure a peaceful settlement to the crisis at the lowest cost.

So far, considerable progress has been made on the political track, with a first round of consultations held in Nairobi from 23 to 27 April. Delegates from 23 local armed groups met with a team from the Joint Secretariat of Kenya and the Democratic Republic of the Congo within the framework of the Nairobi process. Between 17 and 24 May, the Joint Secretariat also visited three provinces in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, meeting with a total of 56 other armed groups and representatives of more than 40 communities in Ituri, North Kivu and South Kivu. Here I would particularly like to thank Ms. Bintou Keita, Special Representative of the Secretary-General in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Head of the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as Mr. Huang Xia, Special Envoy for the Great Lakes Region, for their active support in those consultations.

I should also emphasize that the political consultations are not negotiations with the armed groups. They are being held to support the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme in line with its fundamental principles and in support of the transitional justice strategy for addressing the crimes committed by armed groups against their communities. Over the next few weeks, the consultations will be expanded to include civil society and especially women's organizations, which have not yet been able to participate. The consultations are being conducted in partnership with the Demobilization, Disarmament, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme and will also rely on the expertise of

Congolese grass-roots organizations that have been working for years towards peacebuilding and easing intercommunal tensions, which have not been actively supported by the central Government until now.

The Government's aim is to draw up a consolidated provincial, national and regional action plan by the end of July in order to provide political and institutional support to the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization programme and implement it over the next two years. The Nairobi process is in fact the political and security pillar at the national and regional level that was previously missing from the Government's stabilization and reconstruction plan for the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo.

I listened carefully to all the speakers in today's meeting, and I acknowledge the unanimous support I have heard for the Nairobi process. Unfortunately, however, as members themselves said and as Ms. Pobee described objectively and exhaustively, there are certain armed groups that have rejected the Nairobi process and its principles and methodology. They are the *Coopérative pour le développement du Congo* (CODECO), *Zaire*, *Yakutumba* and the *Mouvement du 23 mars* (M-23). I will not describe them in detail, as I know that Council members have been closely following the situation. I am grateful that the Council is paying special attention to the situation in my country, and it is certainly a positive thing that all members have condemned the M-23, as well as the migratory movements and internal displacements. All the members have asked for sanctions, for which I am also grateful.

I would like to reiterate that I did not come here as a prosecutor or to stir things up by adding fuel to the fire. I came simply because the Security Council is the world's most important forum for peace. The founders of the United Nations did not meet in San Francisco in 1945 with the intention of creating an organization that would spread despair around the world. They established the United Nations to work for peace and security for humankind, to foster solidarity and ensure progress for the peoples of the world. I assure the Council that I will not be making any demands here. However, I feel compelled to ask some questions, questions that I am asked every time that I meet with foreign or even national dignitaries. They ask me: Why is the M-23 is back? Who is supplying it with arms? Where does it get its heavy weapons and experienced fighters, who are attacking not just the *Forces armées*

de la République démocratique du Congo (FARDC), but also United Nations personnel, as if in defiance of the international community?

What are these negative forces, who operate like terrorist groups, seeking? Why is it only now — as the Nairobi process is spreading its wings and the Congolese people are preparing to welcome Pope Francis, whose long-awaited visit includes stops in Goma and Kibumba — that the M-23 is re-emerging, creating insecurity, terror and despair in North Kivu? Why is it that every time the M-23 comes up, it seems as though our brothers and traditional friends in Rwanda, with whom we share culture and blood through our common communities and tribes, are hatching something? The hen hides the chick, as the old proverb says. The answers to those questions are up to each of us.

Frankly, as far as we are concerned, the approach taken by the M-23 and other separatist forces is aimed only at keeping the Democratic Republic of the Congo in a state of instability and undermining the efforts of the East African Community and the implementation of the Nairobi process. The motive behind that approach is that it is necessary to find M-23 its own negotiating space that would lead us to the old pattern of mixing, integration and shuffling of seats in Government in the provinces.

Allow me to tell the Security Council that that will no longer be the case in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. President Tshisekedi Tshilombo, the national Parliament, the national Government and all the people of the Democratic Republic no longer want the patterns that have been applied for 28 years. We have been experiencing this crisis for more than 28 years. There is no longer going to be shuffling. It will no longer be a question of giving political positions without going through the democratic process. I can also affirm that the Head of State, the national Parliament, the Government of the Republic and all the people of the Democratic Republic of the Congo are, and will remain, resolute and committed to upholding the territorial integrity and sovereignty of our country. What is happening today is very serious. What is happening is contrary to the Charter of the United Nations, the Constitutive Act of the African Union and international law. Our community, the Security Council, must address it very seriously.

I said that I did not come to the Security Council today as a prosecutor. My goal and that of the Head

of State and Government, who sent me to the Council in my post, is simply to give an objective picture of the progress made in my country on the path to peace, but also to calmly acquaint the Council with the sad reality that hinders that path towards peace. I call on the Security Council regarding the threat posed by armed groups to peace and security in the Great Lakes subregion and, on behalf of the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, I ask the Council to shoulder its responsibilities in terms of maintaining international peace and security in the world and to act rapidly and effectively before it is too late.

In order to do that, the Democratic Republic of the Congo calls on the Security Council to do the following. First, the Security Council should actively support the Nairobi peace process, initiated by President Uhuru Kenyatta of Kenya and Chairperson of the East African Community.

Secondly, it should call on all the countries of the Great Lakes subregion, in particular the signatories to the April communiqué containing the Nairobi peace plan, to become positively involved in its implementation and to abstain from anything that may impede it.

Thirdly, the Security Council should condemn, as it did in 2013, the activities of the M-23, the Forces démocratiques de libération du Rwanda, the Allied Democratic Forces/National Army for the Liberation of Uganda, the CODECO and all armed groups in the Great Lakes subregion and condemn any outside support to them.

Fourthly, the Council should — and it has already done so in the past, 10 years ago — demand that the M-23 lay down their weapons and withdraw immediately and unconditionally from all occupied areas. In that regard, allow me to make a comment. The Council talked about the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism, which should do its work. I agree with the Council, but that cannot impede the fact that the M-23's activities should cease and that the M-23 should leave the areas that it occupied with the support of those known to the Council. They are two separate things. The mechanism is called on to do its work. It is doing its work. However, it is unacceptable, in any event, for a Government and a responsible Head of State that one single square metre of the national territory be occupied by rebels or an armed group, impeding the country's citizens from going about their business and preventing

the Government from implementing the national development programme. In that context, I would like us to understand each other that there must be reports by the verification mechanism, but, at the same time, we need to return to a situation of democratic normalcy in the country.

Fifthly, the Council should support the implementation of the Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Recovery and Stabilization Programme, which was developed by the Democratic Republic of the Congo. In that context, the Democratic Republic would like to thank the international community, the United Nations, the African Union, the European Union, SADC, ICGLR, the Economic Community of Central African States, the East African Community and our partners, which issued statements of support on the day that the Programme was launched. The World Bank and donors supported that Programme, whose implementation should start without delay.

Lastly, the Democratic Republic of the Congo asks the Security Council to actively be involved to a greater extent in facilitating a frank dialogue with Rwanda so as to allow the return of peace and security in the Great Lakes region. On this issue of the dialogue, allow me to say a few words. Indeed, we should have a dialogue. The Democratic Republic of the Congo and its leaders are open to dialogue. But let us understand each other as to what kind of dialogue we are talking about. One knows that dialogue is like a tango. It is not danced alone; one always needs a partner. One cannot have a dialogue with oneself unless one is mad, and I do not think that in our country there are people who excel in monologues. In plain language, that means political will. Let the Security Council encourage and help the partners to dialogue to bring about that will, and let it be a frank and constructive dialogue. Otherwise, there is no point.

The Council also talked about sanctions and combating impunity. We have to do that, but the Council knows that when we talk about sanctions, and we know that the mapping report is in the archives, who is going to believe in that? When we talk about condemnation, I know that that is diplomatically correct, but condemnation at this level, how many times have we heard that?

Those who believe in condemnation are those who have morals, those who have faith in reason, those who have humanity and those who believe in the United

Nations. I affirm that the Democratic Republic of the Congo believes in the United Nations. We, the people of the Democratic Republic, say that we have confidence in the United Nations and its leaders. That is why we remain at your service, Madam President. We remain at the service of the African Union and subregional organizations so that, together, we can push for a solution for peace as soon as possible in order to put an end to the suffering.

We talked about women — we have seen them in their tens of thousands — children and the elderly, who packed the Rutshuru and Rumagabo roads, fleeing death, carrying kilos of heavy loads on their heads. Let the Security Council shoulder its responsibility.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Rwanda.

Mr. Gatete (Rwanda): I thank you, Madam President, for giving me the opportunity to speak on behalf of Rwanda and on this matter of concern to our subregion. I thank the briefers and the members of the Security Council for their interventions.

Rwanda values building a strong relationship with the Democratic Republic of the Congo. Following the election of President Tshisekedi Tshilombo in January 2019, Rwanda undertook various initiatives to revive bilateral relations, which had deteriorated during the previous Administration. In that context, a number of bilateral agreements and memorandums of understanding were signed, which led to booming cross-border trade between the two countries and an intercommunal relationship between the peoples of the two countries. It is regrettable that all those efforts are being undermined.

Rwanda is deeply concerned about the evolving security situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, which poses a serious threat to peace and security in the region but also directly affects Rwanda. More specifically, on 23 May the Forces armées de la République démocratique du Congo (FARDC), alongside the Forces démocratiques de libération du Rwanda (FDLR), fired shells across the border into Rwanda's territory in the districts of Musanze and Burera. The attack resulted in several serious injuries and damaged property. That was the second shelling this year, following a similar attack on 19 March.

Let me make it clear: the shelling was not on both sides. The shelling came from the Democratic Republic

of the Congo towards Rwanda. It happened twice, and Rwanda never responded. Those incidents have since been confirmed by the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism of the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region.

In addition, two soldiers of the Rwanda Defence Force, who were on patrol along the border, were kidnapped by elements of the FDLR and are now being detained by authorities of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We have requested their protection and immediate release.

Despite those provocations, there has been no acknowledgment or explanation by the FARDC or the authorities of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. The question now is: What is Rwanda expected to do about the next provocation?

Allow me to speak on the issue of the Mouvement du 23 mars (M-23). Rwanda is concerned about the resumption of hostilities between M-23 and FARDC. We call for the de-escalation of those hostilities and urge the parties to abide by the resolutions of the second Heads of State Conclave on the Democratic Republic of the Congo, held on 21 April.

Rwanda rejects the labelling of members of M-23 as Rwandans. They are Congolese nationals, and therefore their grievances should be resolved internally in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. For the purposes of clarification, allow me to recall that in 2013, following the defeat of the M-23 by the Force Intervention Brigade, a number of combatants fled to Rwanda and Uganda. Those who entered Rwanda were disarmed and transferred far away from the border of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which is where they remain, as agreed by the regional mechanism at the time.

Rwanda has also made efforts to facilitate various engagements between those Congolese former M-23 combatants and their Government, which culminated in an agreement and a repatriation road map in 2019. As part of the process, the arms and equipment that the Government of Rwanda seized from the group were handed over to the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. However, there has been a lack of commitment, or interest, on the part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo in implementing the repatriation road map.

Looking further back, it has been more than nine years since the signing in Addis Ababa of the

Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region. That agreement generated considerable hope for disbanding all the armed groups — and there are more than 100 of them — that regularly carry out massacres all over the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, which are routinely met with silence and indifference.

The more recent Nairobi process, led by President Uhuru Kenyatta and President Tshisekedi, also renewed hope for stability in our region through the framework of the expanded East African Community. What we see today, however, is the sliding back into an undesirable state of affairs. The consequences are being borne by innocent civilians.

Even more disturbing is a factor that should be of global concern beyond the Great Lakes region, which is, the blatant resurgence of anti-Rwanda hate speech and calls for genocide that are being encouraged by some officials and politicians in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and spreading through the population. It can be seen on social media and everywhere.

There should never be silence on that issue by the Council and the international community, in view of what happened in Rwanda in 1994. Rwanda is extremely concerned about the military cooperation between the FARDC and the FDLR. The Council should be reminded that the presence of FDLR has caused untold suffering for the people of the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo and perpetuated insecurity in our region for close to three decades now. We urge the United Nations, through the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, not to stand by and watch the perpetuation of the alliance between the FARDC and the FDLR.

In conclusion, I would like to say that Rwanda categorically rejects the allegations by the Democratic Republic of the Congo that Rwanda supports the M-23. That is unfounded and unacceptable. Rwanda has absolutely no interest in destabilizing the Democratic Republic of the Congo. The Government of Rwanda notes that such allegations are a pretext by some spoilers within the Democratic Republic of the Congo to externalize the conflict for domestic political gains, which is dangerous and should be denounced. The Government of Rwanda retains the capacity and justification to defend Rwandans and Rwanda's sovereignty and territorial integrity, in accordance with international law.

We call on the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo to stop the proliferation of hate speech and messages inciting genocidal violence. Rwanda remains committed to existing bilateral, regional and international efforts to stabilize the region through established regional initiatives, including efforts made through the Expanded Joint Verification Mechanism of the International Conference on the Great Lakes Region and the Nairobi process, under the East African Community, as well as through multilateral collaboration, to establish the long-term security, stability and development of the Great Lakes region.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Uganda.

Mr. Ayebare (Uganda): I thank you, Madam President, for giving me an opportunity to speak. Let me also thank the briefers, Ms. Martha Pobe and Special Envoy Huang Xia.

Good bilateral relations between member States in our region are a key ingredient in the maintenance of peace and security. The state of bilateral relations in the region has been on a positive trajectory since the signing of the Peace, Security and Cooperation Framework Agreement for the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Region in February 2013. We have witnessed improved bilateral relations among member States.

As we speak, there is a high-level Ugandan business and investment delegation in Kinshasa, meeting and discussing with our Congolese friends on how to improve trade ties between our two countries. Recently, the Democratic Republic of the Congo joined the East African Community, which will lead to the strengthening and consolidation of existing bilateral relations with all member States.

Improved bilateral relations between Uganda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo are evidenced by the joint operations undertaken against the terrorists of the Allied Democratic Forces (ADF), in accordance with bilateral agreements reached by the two countries, which to date have succeeded in dislodging ADF combatants from some of their camps.

However, the ADF, which is a franchise of the Islamic State in Iraq and the Sham, continues to pose serious security threats to both Uganda and the entire region. We thank the Security Council for designating the ADF and other negative armed groups as terrorist entities.

The bilateral relations in our region have been improving but are being tested by the continued presence of foreign negative forces that include the ADF, the Forces démocratiques de libération du Rwanda and the Résistance pour un État de droit au Burundi in the eastern part of the Democratic Republic of the Congo. As a recipient of refugees from the Democratic Republic, we have, so far, been hosting some 480,000 refugees. My delegation is of the view that our existing regional mechanisms through the International Conference on the Great Lakes region and the recently launched Nairobi Conclave of our Heads of State and Government offer a credible solution to sustaining bilateral relations and addressing all concerns.

Forum shopping and parallel initiatives will be counterproductive. We call on all United Nations officials in the region to work within these mechanisms, since they have been endorsed by the Security Council, the African Union Peace and Security Council and subregional organizations. The Nairobi Conclave proposes both military and political means for dealing with foreign and domestic armed groups, and we should all give it a chance despite the challenges.

Finally, we condemn hate speech in all its forms and manifestations, given the recent history of our region, where over a million people perished in the genocide against the Tutsis in Rwanda. Hatemongers have no place in the discourse to address the challenges facing our region. We call on the United Nations Special Adviser on the Prevention of Genocide to take interest in the recent hate speech that has been coming out of our region. We also call on the Security Council to include language against hate speech in the proposed presidential statement.

The President: There are no more names inscribed on the list of speakers.

Before adjourning the meeting, as this is the last scheduled meeting of the Council for the month of May, I would like to express the sincere appreciation of the delegation of the United States to the members of the Council and to the secretariat of the Council for all the support they have given to us. Indeed, it has been a busy month, and one in which we rallied to consensus on several important issues within our purview. We could not have done it alone or without the hard work, support and positive contributions of every delegation and the representatives of the Secretariat, including conference service officers, interpreters, verbatim reporters and

security staff. As we end our presidency, I know I speak on behalf of the Council in wishing the delegation of Albania extraordinary success in the month of June.

Finally, before I adjourn today's meeting, I would like to say farewell and note that Ms. Hasmik Egian, Director of the Security Council Affairs Division (SCAD), is celebrating her last day at the United Nations. Hasmik joined the United Nations in 1989. Thirty years and 12 assignments on five continents later, she is today embarking on a new phase of her life through retirement. In her past six years as Director of SCAD, Hasmik ensured the Security Council was

able to fulfil its duties to maintain international peace and security.

Hasmik and the team she leads have always kept us moving forward, making the Council function and actually function really well. On behalf of the members of the Council, I want to express our congratulations and our appreciation for a successful career. We thank Hasmik Egian with all of our hearts and wish her the best in the future, and we want her to know that we will miss her so very much.

The meeting rose at 5.15 p.m.